
GTM CHANNELS & EARLY PIPELINE

A Founder's Playbook for Going from Zero to First Revenue

EARLY-STAGE FOUNDER WORKSHOP

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TODAY'S SESSION

180 MINUTES · 4 MODULES

01

THE PRE-REVENUE GTM REALITY

Why most founders get stuck before dollar one

02

CHOOSING YOUR CHANNELS

The framework and sector intelligence for your vertical

03

BUILDING THE EARLY PIPELINE

From first conversation to first contract

04

THE 90-DAY EXECUTION SPRINT

Your action plan, metrics, and traps to avoid

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01

THE PRE-REVENUE GTM REALITY

Why most founders get stuck before dollar one

MODULE 01 · 30 MIN

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THE FOUNDER-LED SALES IMPERATIVE

50+

The best founders do **50+ discovery calls** before writing a single line of sales pitch.

Conversation first, copy second.



You cannot outsource discovery. Hiring a VP Sales before Product-Market Fit is a \$200K mistake most founders make.



First 10 customers buy YOU. Not the product. Credibility transfer from founder to company is everything at this stage.



Live feedback is your compass. Only the founder can pivot the pitch in real-time based on what the market tells you.

KEY INSIGHT

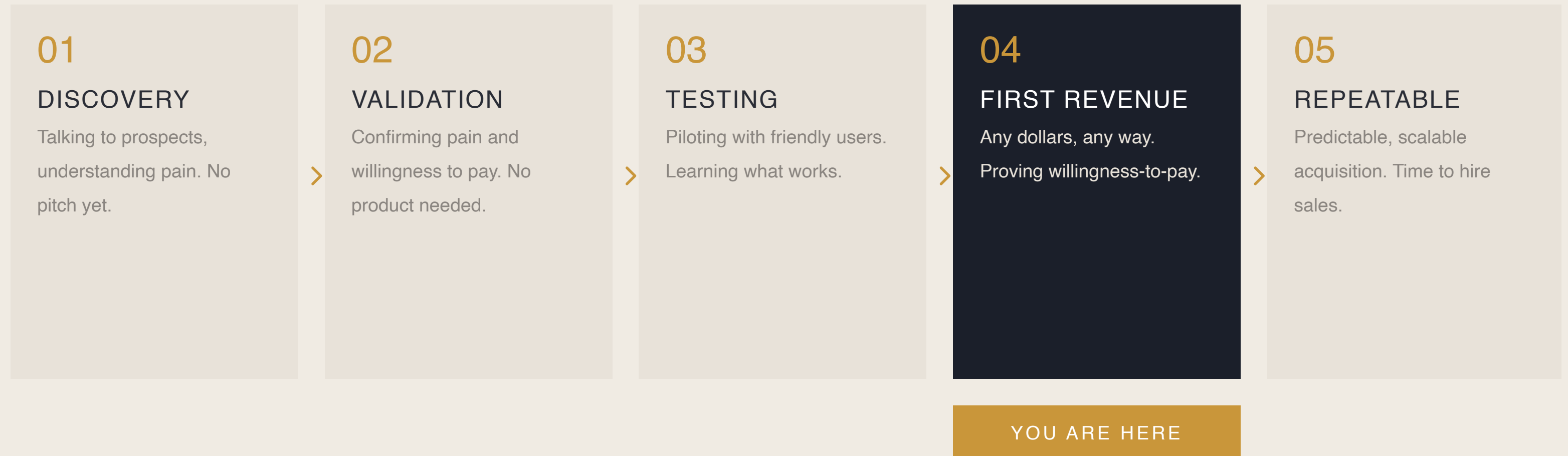
Founder-led sales is not a bug — it's the feature that gets you to Product-Market Fit faster.

The goal at pre-revenue isn't to build a sales machine. It's to build a learning machine that happens to generate revenue.

Every conversation is a data point. Every objection is product feedback. Every "no" gets you closer to the right "yes."

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THE GTM-COMMERCIALIZATION SPECTRUM



Most of this cohort is at stages 1-3. **That's where GTM work matters most.** The work you do in stages 1-3 determines everything. Skip them and you build on quicksand.

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02

CHOOSING YOUR CHANNELS

Not all channels are created equal for early-stage companies

MODULE 02 · 45 MIN

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THE CHANNEL SELECTION FRAMEWORK

DEAL SIZE

HIGH ACV + CONCENTRATED

Direct Sales + ABM

Enterprise deals with named accounts. High touch, relationship-driven, long cycles. Each deal matters.

Best for: Healthcare systems, Fortune 500, government

HIGH ACV + FRAGMENTED

Partnerships + Events

Hard to reach individually. Leverage channel partners, industry conferences, and referral networks.

Best for: Specialty manufacturing, niche B2B services

LOW ACV + CONCENTRATED

Inside Sales + PLG

Buyers cluster in identifiable communities. Product-led growth with inside sales for expansion.

Best for: SMB software, vertical SaaS, developer tools

LOW ACV + FRAGMENTED

Self-Serve + Content/SEO

High volume, low touch. Content marketing, SEO, and self-service onboarding at scale.

Best for: Consumer apps, micro-SaaS, productivity tools

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CUSTOMER CONCENTRATION

SECTOR-SPECIFIC CHANNEL INTELLIGENCE

HEALTHCARE

Channel: Clinical champion → procurement

Cycle: 12-18 months

Gatekeeper: Compliance & legal

Insight: High stickiness once landed. Start with pilot ward, not the C-suite.

ENTERPRISE B2B

Channel: Line-of-business champion

Cycle: 3-6 month POC

Gatekeeper: Procurement & IT

Insight: Pilot-to-paid is the norm. Price the pilot, don't give it away free.

EDTECH

Channel: District (top-down) or teacher (bottom-up) — **pick ONE**

Cycle: Tied to academic calendar

Insight: Parent willingness-to-pay is the real TAM constraint, not student count.

ENERGY / CLEANTECH

Channel: Utility relationships + consortium pilots

Cycle: 6-12 months

Insight: Regulatory tailwinds create urgency. Use them as the forcing function.

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THE CHANNEL-CUSTOMER FIT TEST

THE TEST

1

WHERE DO THEY ALREADY SPEND?

The channel that reaches your customer when they're in buying mode wins.
Don't try to create demand where none exists.

2

WHO INFLUENCES THE DECISION?

Map the buying committee, not just the end user. In healthcare it's compliance. In enterprise it's procurement. Know all the voters.

3

WHAT PROOF DO THEY NEED?

Some need a case study, others a pilot, others just a demo. Match your proof event to their risk tolerance and buying process.

If you can't answer all three questions with **specificity**, you don't have a channel.

You have a guess.

Go talk to 10 more customers before you invest a dollar in any channel.

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03

BUILDING THE EARLY PIPELINE

From first conversation to first contract

MODULE 03 · 45 MIN

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PIPELINE STAGES FOR ZERO-REVENUE STARTUPS



Rule: If a stage has >3 prospects stuck for >30 days, your stage definition is wrong. Simplify.

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ZERO-BUDGET LEAD GENERATION

01 LINKEDIN OUTBOUND

Personalized video messages to ICP. 15 targeted outbounds/day beats 100 generic.

02 WARM INTROS

Map your network's network. Investors, advisors, and other founders open doors.

03 COMMUNITY INFILTRATION

Industry Slack groups, Substack comments, conference talks. Be where they gather.

04 CONTENT MARKETING

Answer the exact question your prospect Googles at 2am. Be the trusted voice.

05 FREE TOOL / CALCULATOR

Demonstrate value before the sales call. Let them experience your insight.

06 STRATEGIC FREE WORK

One lighthouse customer who opens doors is worth 10 paid pilots.

Common thread: At pre-revenue, relevance beats reach. Depth beats breadth. One right conversation beats 100 wrong ones.

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THE FIRST CUSTOMER CONVERSION PLAYBOOK

1

DISCOVERY CALL

80% listening, 20% questioning. Goal is diagnosis, not pitching.

2

VALUE HYPOTHESIS

Articulate their specific ROI in their language, not your pitch deck.

3

PROOF EVENT

2-week pilot, free assessment, or demo with their data. Reduce perceived risk to zero.

4

MUTUAL ACTION PLAN

Jointly document next steps with dates. Deals stall without shared commitment.

5

THE ASK

Don't hint. Don't hope. Propose a start date and ask.

"Based on what we've discussed, I'd like to propose we start a pilot on [date]. Does that work?"

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04

THE 90-DAY EXECUTION SPRINT

From insight to action — your plan for the next quarter

MODULE 04 · 30 MIN

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THE 30-60-90 DAY GTM SPRINT

DAYS 1-30

FOUNDATION

- ▶ Define ICP with painful specificity
- ▶ Map 50 named suspects
- ▶ Choose ONE channel to test
- ▶ Have 10 real customer conversations
- ▶ Document every objection heard

DAYS 31-60

VALIDATION

- ▶ Refine pitch based on feedback
- ▶ Run 5 formal discovery calls
- ▶ Get 2 pilot commitments
- ▶ Build case study from early wins
- ▶ Iterate on pricing model

DAYS 61-90

CONVERSION

- ▶ Convert 1 pilot to paid contract
- ▶ Add 3 new qualified prospects
- ▶ Set Month 4 revenue target
- ▶ Decide: double down or pivot
- ▶ Document repeatable sales motion

Goal: Not scale — signal. One paying customer with a repeatable path beats 100 leads with no clarity.

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THE ONLY 4 METRICS THAT MATTER AT DAY ZERO

10+

CONVERSATIONS / WEEK

The input metric that drives everything. No conversations, no revenue. This is where founders should spend 80% of their time.

3+

QUALIFIED OPPS (MINIMUM)

Prospects who confirmed pain + budget + authority to decide. Not suspects. Not engaged. Qualified.

40%

PILOT RATE (TARGET)

% of qualified opps who agree to a next step. Below 20% = messaging problem. Above 40% = you're onto something.

<45

DAYS TO CLOSE

First conversation to signed contract. Track even if N=1. This is your reality check on channel-market fit.

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THE 5 GTM TRAPS THAT KILL EARLY STARTUPS

01 THE PERFECT WEBSITE TRAP

Spending 3 months on branding before talking to customers. Your landing page won't validate your product.

02 THE DECK-FIRST TRAP

Building a pitch deck instead of a conversation guide. Decks are for investors, not customers.

03 THE CHANNEL FOMO TRAP

Trying LinkedIn + events + content + partnerships simultaneously. You can only run one channel well at pre-revenue.

04 THE "NOT READY" TRAP

Waiting for product v2.0 before selling v0.5. If it solves a real problem, someone will pay for it imperfect.

05 THE SCALE-TOO-EARLY TRAP

Hiring sales before you know what works. A VP of Sales cannot invent your playbook — only execute it.

COMMON SYMPTOM

Each trap shares one symptom: **activity without customer conversation velocity**. If you're not having 10+ real conversations per week, you're in at least one of these traps.

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YOUR NEXT 7 DAYS

Pick your ICP. Name **5** specific people.

Reach out to **3** of them.

Have **one** real conversation.

Everything else is preparation — conversation is the only GTM activity that creates revenue.

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